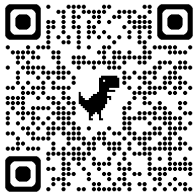


Power Play: Elite Networks and Authoritarian Leadership Challenges

Samuel Morgan Martin

Department of Political Science, University of Toronto

Sept 3rd, 2026



Introduction

- ▶ Why are some challenge entry dictators more successful at consolidating their regime?
- ▶ Leadership challenges: irregular replacement of an incumbent leader by elites.
- ▶ I develop a network theory of leadership challenges and test the theory using network data and case studies of Nigeria's 1983 and 1985 coups.

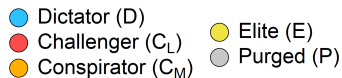
Setup

- ▶ All elites prefer to be an elite rather than be purged; some elites have a strong **unobserved** preference to be the dictator (satisfied vs ambitious types).
- ▶ Elites' decision to lead a challenge is influenced by two considerations: the risk of being purged by the current dictator, and their expected security as the dictator.
- ▶ Expected security depends heavily on the coalition members, because they gain resources and experience by planning and executing successful challenge (Goldring and Matthews 2023).

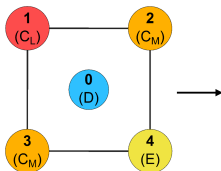
Challenges and purges

- ▶ Elites can only join a challenge if they are connected to the challenge leader.
- ▶ The incumbent is deposed if the challenger mobilizes threshold τ^* of elites.
- ▶ The incumbent can purge elites, but there is a chance that a challenge happens first.

Commitment problems illustrated ($\tau^* = .5$)

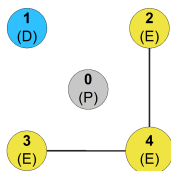


T1: Challenge succeeds

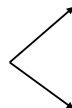


Generic coalition led by Node 1

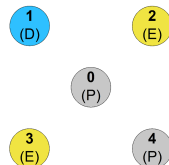
T2: Post-challenge status quo



Node 4 has unique coalition.

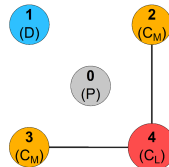


T3: Purge



Purge succeeds; Node 1 is secure as dictator.

T3: No purge

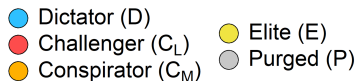


Purge fails; Node 4 deposits Node 1.

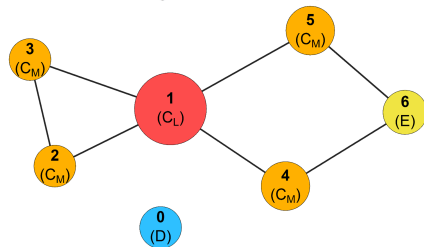
Complementary commitment problems

- ▶ **Post-challenge commitment problem:** coalitions capable of mobilizing against their leader cannot commit leaving their leader in power.
 - ▶ Challengers need a **unique coalition**, a coalition that is unlikely to be mobilized without their participation.
- ▶ **Pre-challenge commitment problem:** elites with a unique coalition cannot commit to not challenging, and dictators cannot commit to not purging them.
- ▶ Elite's network position determines which commitment problem is solved (betweenness centrality).

Post-challenge commitment induces pre-challenge commitment problem ($\tau^* = .5$)

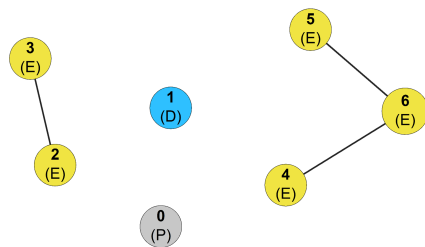


T1: Pre-challenge commitment problem



Unique coalition led by Node 1

T2: Post-challenge status quo



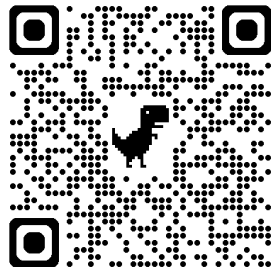
Node 1 is secure as dictator.

Some observable implications

- ▶ High betweenness challengers should be less likely to face subsequent challenges by the coalition that put them into power.
- ▶ High betweenness challengers should implement greater institutional coup proofing reforms such as counterbalancing.
- ▶ Dictators should be more likely to purge high betweenness elites.

Conclusion

- ▶ I highlight two complementary commitment problems, and show how elites' betweenness determines which commitment problem they face.
- ▶ Case study examines recruitment processes as well as commitment problems in two Nigerian military regimes.
- ▶ Contact me at **sammorgan.martin@mail.utoronto.ca** or scan the QR code to read a working draft. Comments are greatly appreciated!



Case studies: Nigeria, 1983-1993

I combine process-tracing with an original network dataset to compare two Nigerian coup episodes (1983, 1985) in a temporal design.

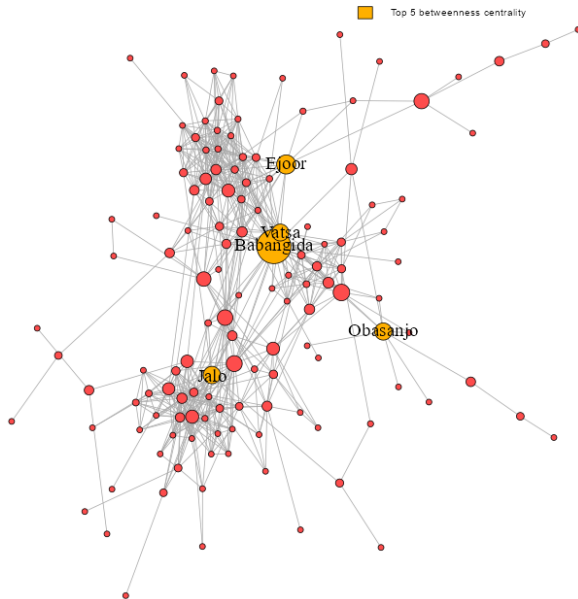
Table: Comparison of Network Metrics and Outcomes: Buhari vs. Babangida

Leader	Betweenness	Outcomes		
		Coup Proofing	Mode of exit	Tenure
Maj.-Gen. Buhari	Low	Low	Removed by own coalition	1.7 years
Maj.-Gen. Babangida	High	High	Voluntary resignation	8 years

Network data

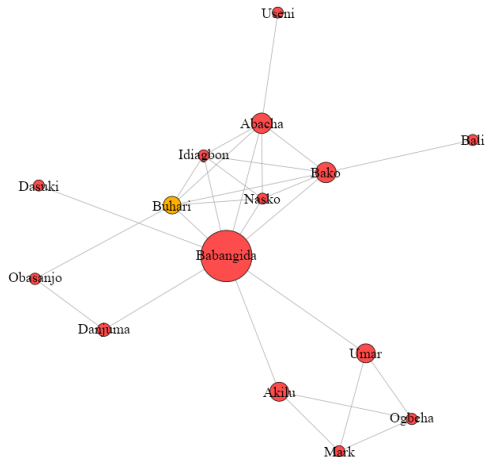
- ▶ Using an open weight language model (Qwen3.5-27b), I extracted actor-org and actor-actor data from a text corpus of 1048 Wikipedia articles.
 - ▶ Text corpus included any article with Wikipedia categories relevant for Nigerian officers.
- ▶ For years of interest, edges were coded if they had a direct relation or overlapped in the same organization in a prior year (binarized, undirected).
- ▶ Connected component for military elites in 1982: 153 actors.

Nigerian military elite network (1982)



Buhari's coup coalition

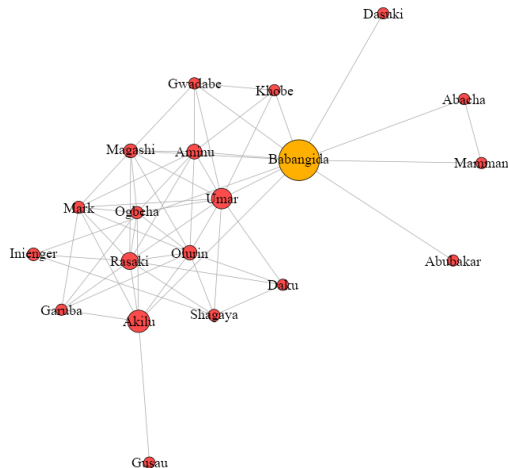
- ▶ Buhari: low betweenness.
- ▶ Babangida (Chief of Army Staff) believed that Buhari was about to purge him; Babangida strikes first.
- ▶ Belief emerges after conflict over control of intelligence service and retirement of Babangida's close ally.



Officers briefed on 1983 coup conspiracy. Membership from Siollun (2025). Edges as of 1982.

Babangida's coup coalition

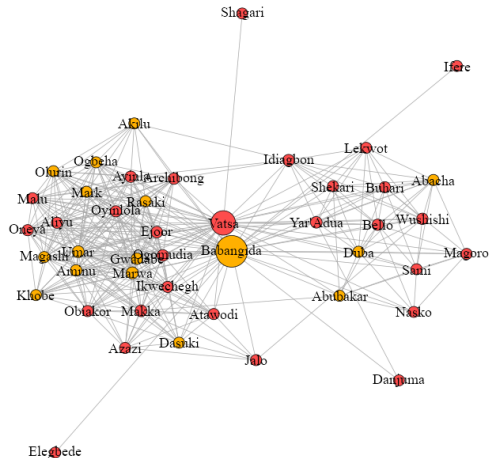
- ▶ Babangida: high betweenness.
- ▶ No purges of coalition; no challenges from his coalition.
- ▶ A (nearly) unique coalition.



Officers briefed on 1985 coup conspiracy. Membership from Omoigui (n.d.). Edges as of 1984.

Selective repression and the Vatsa Conspiracy

- ▶ Vatsa: Babangida's close childhood friend and network doppelganger.
- ▶ Babangida finds questionable evidence linking Vatsa to a coup conspiracy. Vatsa and several others executed.
- ▶ After Vatsa's execution, Babangida implements aggressive institutional coup proofing strategies without provoking opposition; conflicts within coalition do not escalate to purges or challenges.



Babangida and Mamman Vatsa's combined ego networks. Edges as of 1984.

Conclusion

- ▶ I highlight two complementary commitment problems, and show how elites' betweenness determines which commitment problem they face.
- ▶ Case study examines recruitment processes as well as commitment problems in two Nigerian military regimes.
- ▶ Contact me at **sammorgan.martin@mail.utoronto.ca** or scan the QR code to read a working draft. Comments are greatly appreciated!

